ARA
THE ALTAR

SOUTH OF SCORPIUS, ARA LIES WITHIN THE PATH OF THE MILKY WAY. ONE OF THE 48 GREEK CONSTELLATIONS, IT DEPICTS AN ALTAR FROM ANCIENT GREEK MYTHOLOGY.

Ara was the altar where the Greek gods swore allegiance before entering into battle with the Titans for control of the Universe. Eventually, the gods were victorious and the leading god Zeus placed the altar in the sky in gratitude.

The constellation is easy to locate, although its pattern is obscure within the Milky Way's band of stars. Ara's brightest stars, Beta and Alpha, and the star cluster NGC 6193, can be seen with the naked eye. Also noteworthy are globular clusters, such as NGC 6397 and NGC 6362, and Mu Arae, a Sun-like star orbited by at least four planets.

△ **NGC 6326**
Gas is hurtling away from a white dwarf star in the center of this planetary nebula about 11,000 light-years from Earth. In this image, the red color indicates hydrogen and the blue is oxygen.

◁ **NGC 6362**
The center of this globular cluster contains blue stars formed by stellar collisions or the transfer of material between stars, which results in the stars heating up and looking younger than their neighbors.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 63

Brightest stars Beta (β) 2.9, Alpha (α) 3.0

Genitive Arae

Abbreviation Ara

Highest in sky at 10pm June–July

Fully visible 22°N–90°S

CHART 2

MAIN STARS

Alpha (α) Arae
Blue-white main-sequence star
3.0 ⟷ 267 light-years

Beta (β) Arae
Orange supergiant
2.9 ⟷ 645 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 6193 and NGC 6188
Open cluster and an associated emission nebula

NGC 6326
Planetary nebula

NGC 6352
Globular cluster

NGC 6362
Globular cluster

NGC 6397
Globular cluster

Stingray Nebula
Small, young planetary nebula